

ART FAIR

For Art's Sake

The 15th edition of the India Art Fair has many new exhibitors and even a collectible design section

The India Art Fair returns with its 15th edition at Delhi's NSIC exhibition grounds from February 1-4. The 2024 edition of the marquee event sees 30 new exhibitors among a total of 108, including 72 galleries—and seven design studios that will participate in a collectible design section, a first for the fair. Visitors will be able to access works by internationally renowned South Asian artists like Jamini Roy (Chawla Art Gallery, DAG, Dhoomimal Gallery), Dayanita Singh (Nature Morte), Ram Kumar (Sanchit Art), Gauri Gill (Vadehra Art Gallery) et al alongside works by newer names across a range of forms and media.

Fair director Jaya Asokan says, "This year is going to be our biggest yet and I'm delighted to see us expanding into new areas. We want the fair to offer a range of things across art and culture, to have something for everybody. Yes, it is a commercial event and galleries have to make their sales, but by the time the weekend arrives, the crowd is quite diverse. You see a lot of families; we have a lot of schoolkids who visit."

The outdoor installations or large-scale artworks at this year's Fair include '*Deewaaron ke bhi kaan hote hain* (Walls have ears too)' by Sajid Wajid Sheikh, the winner of the first MTArt Agency x India Art Fair Artist Prize. This is an interactive installation on the theme of mass surveillance. The LACMA (Los Angeles County Museum of Art) presents 'Western Flag' by John Gerrard. The installation is a massive LED wall depicting 'Lucas Gusher', the world's first major oil find in Spindletop, Texas, now exhausted, of course. The site is recreated on the LED wall, with a flagpole at its centre, carrying a "flag" of "perpetually-renewing pressurised black smoke".

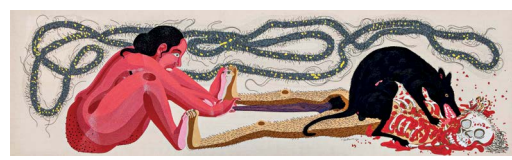
"I first saw the work at a gallery in New York where the LED wall was being mounted," says Asokan. "Of course, the first time you see an artwork in person, it's an emotional experience, it's personal. Later, we got in touch with Michael Govan of LACMA and told him we wanted to bring 'Western Flag' to the India Art Fair. Once we met him, the process was quite organic; he visited some galleries here and we figured out the details. Michael will also be speaking at a panel during the fair."

In line with the Fair's accessibility agenda, the 15th edition will also host its Inclusion Lab, with activities and workshops for people of all ages and abilities. This has been programmed by Siddhanth and Nirali Shah of Access For All, supported by The Marg Foundation. "Accessibility for all is a big part of our vision," says Asokan. "In terms of the exhibits themselves, we want the widest possible cross-section of styles, forms and traditions. It's important that we put craftspeople on the same level playing field as artists, for example. People working in new media should get the same platform as those working with traditional forms like painting and sculpture." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha









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NEW VISION

(Clockwise from top): 'Top Stick Cherry', painted bronze brass by Jonathan Trayte; 'Untitled', reverse serigraph on polycarbonate by Madhvi Parekh; 'Strong Desire', pencil and hand embroidery on linen by T. Venkanna; 'Untitled', papier mache by Skarma Sonam Tashi; 'Untitled', metal origami on paper by Keita Miyazaki